
PAPERBOY

MONDAY, AUGUST 24, 2026

Washington's largest-ever economic offensive against Iran is due at two o'clock this afternoon, and nothing has been published yet.

AI

A stealth model called Ox Alpha appears on OpenRouter and nobody knows whose it is

WHAT HAPPENED

A free reasoning model pitched at coding and long agentic runs turned up on OpenRouter late last week, listed only as "developed and operated by a third-party provider who has chosen to remain anonymous during this preview." Speculation has swung between the Chinese firm Z.ai's GLM line and an unreleased build of Microsoft's MAI, with no consensus. Stripe chief executive Patrick Collison, whose company is buying OpenRouter, called it "very impressive" on X. The analyst Andrew Curran noted the early GLM theory has decayed: "this morning people seem less sure of anything." [TechCrunch's account](#) gives conflicting debut dates, so treat the timing loosely.

WHAT IT MEANS

Stealth launches on a neutral router are now the standard way to test a frontier model against rivals without wearing a bad benchmark in public. That it works at all shows how far the inference layer has commoditised: the router, not the lab, is where models get compared.

WATCH NEXT

Whether the provider unmaskes, and whether Stripe's ownership of OpenRouter survives hosting anonymous previews.

A London startup says a 27-billion-parameter model beat Claude and GPT at replicating science

WHAT HAPPENED

Inherent, founded by four DeepMind alumni, says its agent Faraday outperformed Anthropic's Claude Opus 4.8 and OpenAI's GPT-5.5 at reproducing published scientific findings - while running on a 27-billion-parameter Qwen 3.6 base. The company has raised a \$50m seed and plans to grow from twelve staff to twenty-five by year end. Chief scientist Edward Hughes said the method mattered more than the scoreboard: "What was most interesting to us about this was not so much the result of beating those frontier agents - which of course we liked - but was actually the way we went about building this." The approach is reinforcement learning aimed at giving agents "research taste." The benchmark is [the company's own](#) and has not been independently verified.

WHAT IT MEANS

If a small model with a better harness beats frontier systems on a bounded scientific task, the advantage sits in scaffolding rather than parameter count. Most of the capital raised in the past two years bet the other way.

WATCH NEXT

Publication of the benchmark, and whether anyone outside Inherent reproduces it.

Dutch regulator fines Uber nearly €825m for firing drivers by algorithm

WHAT HAPPENED

The Dutch Data Protection Authority fined Uber close to €825m (about \$966m) for deactivating driver accounts through automated processes without adequate warning or human oversight, including permanent deactivations the regulator says received no human review. The [penalty was announced on 21 August](#) and picked up by the trade press on the 23rd. It follows Dutch fines on Uber of €290m in 2024 and €10m before that. Uber disputes the findings - it says most suspensions are brief, that permanent ones do get human review, and that the fine is disproportionate - and will appeal. On the standard tally it is the second-largest GDPR penalty ever, behind Meta's €1.2bn.

WHAT IT MEANS

This is the first nine-figure enforcement aimed squarely at Article 22, the right not to be subject to a purely automated decision. Any company putting agents into hiring, credit or account termination now has a priced example of what the downside looks like.

WATCH NEXT

The appeal, and whether other European regulators borrow the theory.

Nvidia tells customers AI server prices go up more than 15% in early 2027

WHAT HAPPENED

Bloomberg reported on 22 August that Nvidia has warned customers that AI server prices will rise by more than 15% for systems shipping in early 2027, varying by generation and memory configuration across both the Vera Rubin and Grace Blackwell lines. Memory is the cause. Per GF Securities, it now accounts for roughly 29% of the \$2.1m bill of materials on a Vera Rubin VR200, against Nvidia's internal target of 20%. One mitigation under discussion is cutting Vera CPU SOCAMM memory from about 55TB to 28TB per rack while holding HBM4 at 20.7TB. TrendForce expects HBM bit shipments to grow 50-60% in 2027 and still fall short of demand. [Every version traces to the same Bloomberg report](#); Nvidia did not respond to requests for comment, and a DigiTimes figure of 17% is derived from it rather than independent of it.

WHAT IT MEANS

Hyperscalers can hedge this with long-term memory contracts. Companies buying finished systems from Dell, HPE or Supermicro cannot, so the increase lands hardest on the second tier - exactly the buyers the AI build-out was supposed to be widening to.

WATCH NEXT

Nvidia's Q2 FY2027 results on Wednesday 26 August, and whether anyone gets management to address 2027 pricing.

Samsung announces a record payout and the market marks it down 8.7%

WHAT HAPPENED

The KOSPI fell 3.12% on Monday to 6,696.96, with [Samsung Electronics down 8.70%](#) and SK hynix down 3.41%, after investors judged Samsung's shareholder-return plan - 90 to 110 trillion won, announced Friday, roughly five times its previous record - structurally weaker than SK hynix's. The objection is mechanical: Samsung neither raised its standing return policy nor committed to cancelling treasury shares, where SK hynix pairs its buyback with cancellation. "Repurchasing and canceling shares tends to have a more direct impact on share prices than paying cash dividends, even if the total amount returned to shareholders is the same," said Lee Young-gon of Toss Securities. Foreign investors sold a net 3.69 trillion won, institutions 1.29 trillion won; retail bought 3.32 trillion won.

WHAT IT MEANS

A record cheque earned a record sell-off. Seoul is pricing the mechanism rather than the headline number, and share cancellation - not dividend size - is now the bar a Korean chaebol has to clear.

WATCH NEXT

Whether Samsung amends the structure of the plan before its next board meeting.

Alibaba raises \$10.2bn for AI, falls 9.7%, and loses Michael Burry

WHAT HAPPENED

Alibaba priced a HK\$80bn (\$10.2bn) sale of 710 million new shares at HK\$112.70, an 8.4% discount to Friday's close, with proceeds earmarked for AI infrastructure and "full-stack AI capabilities." The book was roughly three times covered. The stock still [fell 9.67% to HK\\$111.10](#), below the placement price and its lowest since 30 July, pulling the Hang Seng down 2.15%. Michael Burry disclosed he had exited Alibaba entirely and rotated into JD.com, saying he could not support the issuance and that return on invested capital would keep falling as the company spends on AI. Quartz, citing Bloomberg, calls it Hong Kong's largest follow-on since Prosus's \$14.7bn Tencent sale in 2021. It is expected to close on 26 August.

WHAT IT MEANS

Equity is now the funding instrument of choice for AI capital spending in Asia, and existing shareholders are being asked to pay for it in advance. Burry's exit is the bear case compressed into one trade: the spending is certain, the return is not.

WATCH NEXT

The 26 August close, and whether Tencent or Baidu follow with placements of their own.

Gold near a three-month high as the Treasury leans on the long end

WHAT HAPPENED

Spot gold held at \$4,627.69 an ounce, up 0.5%, with December futures at \$4,683.85; silver slipped to \$68.79 and platinum to \$1,872.74. The driver is the Treasury buying back government debt to hold down long-dated yields, pushing both yields and the dollar lower. Gold rose more than 5% last week, a third consecutive weekly gain, and gold-backed ETFs recorded their [largest single-day inflow since September 2025](#). US government debt passed \$40tn this month. Deutsche Bank's George Saravelos describes the combination of expanded buybacks and coordinated US-Japan currency intervention as "soft-form financial repression policies aimed at containing the long-end of the US yield curve." The 10-year sat at 4.709% on Monday, the 30-year at 5.251%.

WHAT IT MEANS

If the price of Treasuries is not allowed to fall, the adjustment has to appear somewhere else - and the dollar is the somewhere else. Gold is pricing that, not inflation.

WATCH NEXT

Jackson Hole, 27-29 August, and the next buyback operation schedule.

Apple said to be launching a \$2,000-plus foldable in September

WHAT HAPPENED

Fortune reported on Monday morning that Apple will introduce its first foldable iPhone, expected to be called the iPhone Ultra, at an event around 9 September at a price above \$2,000. Reported specifications include no telephoto camera, Touch ID rather than Face ID, a larger internal display with iPad-style app layouts, and a new hinge. The account is [assembled from Bloomberg's Mark Gurman on timing](#) and 9to5Mac on naming. Apple has confirmed nothing - not the product, not the name, not the date.

WHAT IT MEANS

Apple has let Samsung own folding phones for seven years while the category stayed a rounding error. Entering now, at a price above \$2,000, is a bet that the hinge problem is finally solved rather than that the market is finally large.

WATCH NEXT

An actual invitation from Apple, which would normally land about ten days before the event.

STARTUPS

Starcloud raises \$250m at \$2.3bn to buy rockets before everyone else does

WHAT HAPPENED

Starcloud, which builds data centres designed to operate in orbit, raised \$250m as an extension to its Series A at a \$2.3bn valuation, led by Manhattan West Ventures with \$25m from Nvidia alongside Cisco, Benchmark and EQT. It extends a \$170m Series A closed in March. The round is explicitly about securing launch capacity before it is gone. "We can see what's coming - we're going to need to book an enormous amount of launch," chief executive Philip Johnston told [TechCrunch](#), adding that "obviously if we can't book any SpaceX launch capacity in 2029, that will be challenging for us." (TechCrunch's URL says \$200m; its headline, its text and GeekWire all say \$250m.)

WHAT IT MEANS

Orbital compute is an energy and cooling arbitrage - uninterrupted sun, free vacuum, no grid interconnection queue. The binding constraint is lift, and lift is being bought up by everyone simultaneously, which is why this is a land-grab round rather than a build round.

WATCH NEXT

Whether Starcloud secures a Starship manifest slot.

NEURA buys a cleaning-robot maker to put a brain in it

WHAT HAPPENED

NEURA Robotics said on Monday that its NEURA Mobile Robots unit had acquired 100% of ADLATUS Robotics, an Ulm-based maker of autonomous cleaning and sweeping machines used in industrial, logistics, healthcare and commercial sites. Terms were not disclosed. NEURA plans to add sensing and fold the machines into its Neuraverse platform so they can recognise surfaces, interpret situations and learn from deployment. "We want to give machines like this a new brain," said founder and chief executive David Reger. "Cleaning is a perfect example of what physical AI can change." [Single-outlet, from a company announcement.](#)

WHAT IT MEANS

The cheap route into physical AI is not to build a robot but to buy proven hardware doing a dull, high-volume job and retrofit the intelligence. Cleaning is the ideal first target: repetitive, low-margin, and nobody wants the shift.

WATCH NEXT

Whether a deal value ever surfaces, and which unglamorous category gets bought next.

Kazimi raises €2.2m to work out which of your users are real

WHAT HAPPENED

Berlin-based Kazimi announced an oversubscribed €2.2m pre-seed led by Market One Capital, with IBB Ventures and operator angels including former Rovio chief technology officer Petri Hyökyranta and former Supercell data scientist Janne Peltola. It sells cryptographic, privacy-preserving proofs that let mobile app developers verify which signals in their first-party data come from real users rather than bots. The founding team came out of Adjust, the attribution company AppLovin bought in 2021. "Until now it has been technically impossible for app developers to have true visibility on which signals originate from real users and which signals come from bots," said co-founder [Andreas Naumann](#). [Single-outlet.](#)

WHAT IT MEANS

First-party data is now training data as well as advertising data, which doubles the cost of bot contamination - a poisoned signal no longer just wastes ad spend, it teaches the model something false.

WATCH NEXT

Whether the large attribution vendors build this in-house instead of buying it.

Trump tells communities refusing data centres they are making a mistake

WHAT HAPPENED

In an interview with his former lawyer Michael Cohen, aired in full on Sunday, Trump defended the AI data-centre build-out against mounting local opposition. He rejected the argument that data centres strain the electrical grid on the grounds that operators generate their own power: "They're making their own power plants. They're building the most beautiful, you've never seen power plants like this." He added that "communities that don't take a data center, they're making a mistake" because they bring "tremendous amounts of jobs and money," and [claimed the US is well ahead of China](#) on AI. The administration has been pressing companies to finance their own generation while easing environmental rules on dedicated plants.

WHAT IT MEANS

Local siting fights, not chips or capital, are the binding constraint on American compute. The White House is choosing to argue with them in public rather than preempt them through federal permitting - a slower route. The second story here is Cohen, once the government's star witness against Trump, now conducting a friendly interview.

WATCH NEXT

County and state siting votes this autumn, particularly in Ohio and Virginia.

Warsh gets his first Jackson Hole this week

WHAT HAPPENED

The Kansas City Fed's symposium runs [27-29 August on "Financial Innovation: Implications for Payments and Policy"](#) - confirmed on its own page, which names no speakers at all. It will be the first for Kevin Warsh, who took office as Fed chair on 22 May 2026 for a term ending 21 May 2030; Jerome Powell remains on the Board as a governor. Markets spent the weekend betting on whether Warsh signals a September cut, though neither the Fed nor the Kansas City Fed has published a programme or a speaking slot, and the Fed's 2026 speech archive shows nothing scheduled. July's FOMC held at 3.50-3.75% with three dissents - all for a rise, not a cut.

WHAT IT MEANS

A first Jackson Hole is where a chair sets a frame that outlives the meeting. Warsh's record is of saying considerably less than markets want him to, and the three hawkish dissents in July are the more useful signal about where the committee actually sits.

WATCH NEXT

Whether the Kansas City Fed publishes a programme before Thursday.

The biggest sanctions package on Iran yet is due at two o'clock, and nothing is published

WHAT HAPPENED

Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent has scheduled a press conference for 2:00 PM ET today to unveil what he calls "the single greatest financial offensive ever marshalled against an adversary," aimed at governments that sustain Iran's economy, not only companies. As of this morning nothing had been released: OFAC's recent-actions feed carried nothing after 21 August, so no entity, vessel or individual counts exist yet. Iran's Supreme National Security Council secretary Mohsen Rezaei said that "if the economic war continues, not a single drop of oil will be exported through the Strait of Hormuz," and that states joining US sanctions would commit "an act of war." The rial hit a record low on Sunday, the dollar passing 200,000 tomans on the free market for the first time. China buys roughly [90% of Iran's oil](#).

WHAT IT MEANS

Measures aimed at third countries only bite if those countries comply, making this a test of American leverage over Beijing more than over Tehran. The flows are disputed: the administration claims an eight-million-barrel-a-day average through the strait; the tanker tracker Vortexa says six to seven.

WATCH NEXT

The 2pm announcement, then the OFAC list itself. Whether a single Chinese oil buyer is named is the whole story.

Burnham goes to Kyiv and hands over missile blueprints

WHAT HAPPENED

British Prime Minister Andy Burnham made his first international trip to Kyiv on Monday for Ukraine's Independence Day, joined by nearly a dozen European leaders including European Council President António Costa for a Coalition of the Willing meeting, with the French and German leaders online. The deliverable was British approval for MBDA to release classified information about UK components in the SCALP long-range missile, letting France and Ukraine pursue local production. "The UK is behind you today and for as long as it takes," [Burnham said](#). Russia's defence ministry claimed it downed 351 Ukrainian drones overnight and said three teenagers were killed in Krasnodar - its own account of its own operations, unverified.

WHAT IT MEANS

Releasing missile intellectual property is a heavier commitment than another tranche of finished weapons. It moves Ukraine from consuming European deep-strike stock toward making its own - a decision that outlasts any particular government.

WATCH NEXT

Whether France and Ukraine announce an actual SCALP production line.

Four kites put mass evacuation back on the table in Gaza

WHAT HAPPENED

Israeli strikes on 23 August killed at least three Palestinians, including four-year-old Muhammad Abdel Salam Taha, across Az-Zawayda, al-Shujaiyya and Khan Younis. Netanyahu and Defence Minister Israel Katz warned that if "the launches toward Israel do not stop immediately" the military would "act to intensify strikes" and evacuate areas launching kites, drones and balloons. The trigger was four kites launched over the weekend, on which [the Israeli military found nothing suspicious](#). Hamas spokesman Hazem Qassem called them "children's toys" and accused Netanyahu of "fabricated pretexts." Al Jazeera puts the toll since October's ceasefire at 1,286, and above 73,400 since October 2023 - health-ministry figures.

WHAT IT MEANS

The ceasefire is being held together by a threshold nobody has written down. When four kites carrying nothing are enough to put evacuation of a populated area on the table, the agreement is doing less work than the restraint of the parties.

WATCH NEXT

Whether evacuation orders are actually issued, and how Egypt and Qatar respond.

SOURCES

TechCrunch - Who's behind the new stealth model Ox Alpha?

TechCrunch - Inherent says its AI teammate outperformed Anthropic and OpenAI

TechCrunch - Uber faces fine of nearly \$1bn over automated driver suspensions

Tom's Hardware - Nvidia reportedly warns customers of 15% AI server price hikes

Korea Times - KOSPI plunges more than 3% as Samsung, SK hynix shares tumble

Investing.com - Alibaba shares plunge as Burry exits stake

Investing.com - Gold holds near three-month high as Treasury moves fuel demand

Fortune - Treasury bond buybacks and "financial repression"

Fortune - Apple to launch \$2,000 foldable iPhone Ultra in September

TechCrunch - Starcloud raises for orbital data centers as launch options dry up

Tech.eu - NEURA Robotics acquires ADLATUS

Tech.eu - Kazimi raises €2.2m pre-seed

Axios - Trump defends data centers in Michael Cohen interview

Kansas City Fed - 2026 Jackson Hole Economic Symposium

Federal Reserve - Board members (Chair Kevin Warsh)

NPR - Bessent to unveil new economic sanctions on Iran

OFAC - Recent Actions (nothing after 21 August as of this morning)

Fortune - Iran war outlook, Hormuz flows and the Oman corridor

Shafaq - Iran's rial hits record low as dollar tops 200,000 tomans

GOV.UK - Prime Minister Andy Burnham visits Kyiv

Al Jazeera - Israeli strikes near Gaza refugee camp